

POLITICAL THEATRE
Left, Dharmendra Pradhan being felicitated outside Parliament following his resignation, Jul. 27; Union ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh meet CJP spokespersons, Jul. 25

PTI

logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

On the face of it, this appears to be a strong response to the NEET controversy. But there have been two detailed reform blueprints before—the K. Radhakrishnan Committee report of 2024 and the one by the Parliamentary Standing Committee the following year. Both identified weaknesses in the NTA and suggested specific ways to prevent examination leaks. Many of those recommendations remain unheeded.

THE BJP MAY HAVE TIDED OVER THE CURRENT NEET CRISIS FOR THE MOMENT, BUT THE WIDER ISSUE OF THE JOB-EDUCATION MISMATCH PERSISTS

The Radhakrishnan panel's proposals on question papers were remarkably specific. It called for a trusted pool of vetted experts, clear rules for selecting paper-setters and vetters, conflict-of-interest declarations and non-disclosure agreements. Setters were preferably not to work in their home cities. Separate teams were to prepare multiple papers, while language experts had to certify that no outsider had seen the content. The panel also wanted large question banks from which papers could be assembled close to the exam date through a secure and randomised process. This would break the direct link between an individual expert and the final paper.

These proposals addressed the very point at which the 2026 NEET leak allegedly occurred. According to the investigation detailed in the documents, some experts worked both as paper-setters and translators, giving a small group access to large parts of the examination. Had the recommended separation of roles, conflict checks, secure question banks and random selection been followed, the alleged insiders might never have known which questions would appear and the leak could plausibly have been prevented.

Of the 101 recommendations proposed by the Radhakrishnan committee, the government has accepted all—but implemented only 57 so far. The measures delayed include multi-session testing for very large examinations, a multi-stage NEET-UG and a hybrid model in which encrypted papers travel digitally and are printed at the examination centre. The reforms introduced for 2025 hardened the logistics chain but left the paper-setting stage largely untouched. That is exactly where the system broke in 2026. The new task force must therefore define the terms of reference for its work, audit why the earlier recommendations were not implemented and translate the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations into an operational blueprint. Otherwise, its formation will appear as nothing more than a tactical move to quell the dissent on the streets.

To win Gen Z's trust, Modi will have to address not just the current NEET crisis but also the larger issue of mismatch between education and jobs. The numbers are unambiguous. The Periodic Labour Force Survey for June 2026 puts unemployment among 15- to 29-year-olds at 16.2 per cent against an overall rate of 5.5 per cent; the figure is higher (18.2 per cent) in urban India, and is above 25 per cent for young women. Annual data is even more dismal. Unemployment for those with secondary education and above was 6.5 per cent in 2025 against 0.3 per cent for the non-literate.